

EVERGAME-GAMEDay

Identity, Access, and Vendor Strategy

SteerCo Briefing

EVERGAME Program Alignment | October 2025

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Executive Summary

The EVERGAME MVP has successfully launched and achieved platform stability, but it has also revealed critical operational challenges that demand immediate attention. These issues stem from legacy processes deeply rooted in manual spreadsheets, unverified personal email addresses, and ad hoc onboarding procedures that introduce friction, security vulnerabilities, and audit risk across the organization.

Current Challenge

Decentralized identity management creates operational blind spots, duplicated accounts, and delayed incident response. Personal emails for vendor access introduce unacceptable security exposure.

Recommended Solution

Establish a **Unified External Access and Vendor Governance Model**, anchored in Okta as the single source of truth for all user identities, access rights, and lifecycle management.

Strategic Enablement

This foundation unlocks two critical future initiatives: the **WhatsApp sunset strategy** for secure communications and **international expansion capabilities** supporting global scale.

Strategic Context

Current State (*Enterprise*)

The NFL's current identity and access management approach reflects organic growth rather than intentional design, creating operational challenges that compound over time.

- Decentralized onboarding processes with no standardized approval workflows
- Unverified personal email addresses used for temporary and vendor accounts
- Fragmented communications landscape across WhatsApp, Teams, and SMS
- Persistent role-task mismatches resulting in assignment errors and costly rework
- No unified audit trail for access decisions or user lifecycle events

Future State Vision

A modernized approach that positions the NFL for operational excellence, security assurance, and global scalability.

- Single governed identity model spanning all user populations and access types
- Secure, auditable communication channels replacing high-risk shadow IT tools
- Scalable global architecture supporting federated identities and regional compliance frameworks
- Automated lifecycle management reducing manual overhead and human error
- Comprehensive evidence capture for audit readiness and regulatory compliance

Core Issues Identified

The EVERGAME MVP deployment revealed five interconnected challenge areas that require coordinated resolution. Each issue creates cascading impacts across security, operations, and compliance domains.

Focus Area	Challenge	Impact
Identity & Authentication	No centralized source of truth for user identities across systems and platforms	Account duplication, dormant credentials, delayed security incident resolution
Vendor Access	Inconsistent onboarding procedures, unmanaged personal email addresses	Elevated vendor risk exposure, significant audit gaps, compliance vulnerability
Role Mapping	Roles not properly aligned with actual task assignments and permissions	Incorrect work assignments, user confusion, operational inefficiency
Communications	Heavy dependence on WhatsApp and other shadow IT communication tools	Critical security risk, data fragmentation, no audit trail for decisions
International Readiness	No federated identity model or regional compliance framework	Severe limitations on global scale, regulatory compliance exposure

These challenges are not isolated technical issues, they represent fundamental gaps in governance that create operational drag and strategic risk. Addressing them systematically is essential for both immediate stability and future growth.

Future Strategy Enablement

A. Secure Communications Transition (WhatsApp Sunset)

The transition away from WhatsApp represents a critical security and compliance milestone for the NFL. However, success depends entirely on establishing stable identity infrastructure first.

- Identity Stabilization**
The **critical dependency** for WhatsApp replacement. Without verified user identities, no secure communication platform can function properly.
- In-Platform Communication**
Once complete, EverGame enables secure messaging tied to authenticated identities, with every interaction traceable to verified users.
- External Collaboration**
Teams guest channels provide league-approved mechanisms for external collaboration, replacing informal WhatsApp groups.
- Audit Readiness**
Every task assignment and message traces back to an authenticated user, creating comprehensive audit trails for compliance and security reviews.

 Decision Required

Confirm inactivity threshold policy (proposed 30–90 day tiered approach) before communication platform rollout can proceed.

B. International Scale and Compliance Enablement

The new identity governance model transforms EVERGAME from a domestic platform into the **foundation for global NFL operations**. This architectural shift enables international expansion while maintaining security and regulatory compliance across jurisdictions.

Global Identity Gateway

Okta serves as the central authentication authority, federating seamlessly with regional identity providers across Europe, Asia-Pacific, and other markets.

Compliance

Framework for GDPR, UK Data Protection Act, APPI (Japan), and other regional frameworks, ensuring operations meet local regulatory requirements.

Adaptive Security

Geo-aware access controls, localization capabilities, and conditional security policies that adapt to regional risk profiles and operational needs.

Decision Required

Confirm whether to include **regional tenancy architecture** and **conditional access policies** in current scope or defer to Phase II implementation (2026).

Root Challenges and Mitigations

Each core challenge has identifiable root causes and targeted mitigation strategies. This table maps the path from current problems to implemented solutions.

Challenge	Root Cause	Mitigation Strategy
No Single Source of Truth	Manual onboarding across disconnected systems	Establish Okta as the definitive identity authority with automated provisioning and canonical user records
Unverified Vendor Access	Personal email addresses, no formal review cycles	Implement Federated Vendor Access Model with tiered MFA requirements and quarterly access reviews
Role-Task Misalignment	No canonical role mapping or rules engine	Conduct comprehensive Role Mapping Sprint and publish validated Rules Matrix for task assignments
Shadow Communications	WhatsApp dependence, no approved alternatives	Deploy governed communications via EverGame platform and approved Teams guest channels
Undefined Inactivity Policy	No shared organizational standard or enforcement	Establish tiered deactivation thresholds (League decision required for final parameters)

Recommended Phased Plan

Phase 1: Foundation October – November 2025

- Approve External Access Model and Okta group structures
- Conduct comprehensive Role Mapping Sprint
- Publish Rules Matrix v1 for task assignments
- Implement inactivity monitoring infrastructure (pending policy approval)
- Freeze manual onboarding processes, redirect to governed workflows

Phase 3: Global Enablement 2026 – 2027

- Activate international federation with regional identity providers
- Deploy regional tenancy architecture for data residency
- Introduce geo-aware access policies and conditional authentication
- Extend Evidence Ledger for global compliance requirements
- Scale compliance dashboards for multi-jurisdictional reporting

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Phase 2: Integration December 2025 – Q1 2026

- Enable SCIM integration for automated lifecycle management
- Launch governed communications platform (EverGame + Teams)
- Initiate quarterly vendor access review process
- Complete WhatsApp sunset planning and communication
- Deploy enhanced audit and compliance dashboards

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Strategic Outcomes

The proposed identity governance model delivers transformative benefits across security, operations, compliance, and strategic positioning. These outcomes build on each other to create sustainable competitive advantage.

Unified Identity Governance

One authoritative source of truth across the entire league, eliminating account duplication and enabling instant access decisions.

Operational Efficiency

Dramatically reduced access friction, fewer assignment errors, and automated workflows that eliminate manual overhead.

Secure Communications

Verified collaboration channels with full audit trails, replacing high-risk WhatsApp with governed alternatives.

Vendor Assurance

Tiered access controls and comprehensive lifecycle management reduce exposure while maintaining operational flexibility.

Global Readiness

Federated architecture prepared for international operations with regional compliance built into the foundation.

Cost-Controlled Security

MFA-protected access without license sprawl, using smart guest access policies and tiered authentication.

Decisions & Dependencies

The following decisions represent critical path items that determine project velocity, scope boundaries, and strategic direction. Each requires explicit approval from designated stakeholders within specified timeframes.

Decision	Owner	Timing	Impact
Identity Governance Model Approval	NFL IT / Operations	Immediate	Unlocks all access management and role alignment work streams
Inactivity Threshold Policy	NFL IT Security	October 2025	Guides automation rules, licensing models, and communications platform design
Vendor Access Framework	NFL Ops + Security	October 2025	Defines vendor onboarding processes, MFA requirements, and cost model
Role Mapping Validation	NFL Operations	October 2025	Enables automation of task assignments and eliminates role-task mismatches
WhatsApp Replacement Plan	NFL IT + Communications	November 2026	Enables secure communications rollout and shadow IT elimination
International Federation Scope	NFL Leadership	December 2026	Determines 2026–27 architecture roadmap and global expansion capabilities

Commercial Alignment (Preview)

The following change orders will formalize scope expansion for communications migration and international enablement. Final commercial terms await completion of prerequisite policy decisions and technical assessments.

Change Order #1

Communications Migration

Scope: WhatsApp sunset and transition to EverGame integrated communications plus governed Teams guest channels.

Dependencies: Identity stabilization completion, inactivity policy confirmation, role mapping validation.

Timeline: To be scoped post-identity stabilization and policy finalization.

Value: Eliminates shadow IT risk, establishes audit trails, enables secure external collaboration.

Change Order #2

International Federation Enablement

Scope: Global identity federation, regional tenancy architecture, geo-aware access controls, and compliance framework implementation.

Dependencies: Completion of global readiness assessment, regional compliance requirements analysis.

Timeline: To be scoped after XXXXX assessment completion.

Value: Unlocks international expansion, ensures regulatory compliance, enables scalable global operations.

❏ Detailed statements of work, cost estimates, and implementation timelines will be delivered following completion of prerequisite league policy decisions and technical dependency milestones.

Next Steps

The following action items establish clear accountability and create momentum toward identity governance stabilization and strategic capability enablement.

1 Confirm Identity and Inactivity Decisions

NFL IT and Security leadership to approve identity governance model and establish inactivity threshold policy by mid-October 2025.

2 Finalize Role Mapping Sprint Deliverables

Complete role mapping validation workshops and publish Rules Matrix v1 for production deployment and automation.

3 Maintain Biweekly SteerCo Cadence

Continue regular governance meetings for decision approval, progress tracking, and cross-functional alignment on dependencies.

4 Prepare Communications Migration Planning

Initiate detailed planning for WhatsApp sunset and secure communications rollout, targeting November 2025 kickoff.

5 Deliver Change Order Proposals

NOVATE to prepare detailed change order documentation following completion of league policy alignment and dependency resolution.

